This thread describes some of the early warning signs of a potential resignation and ways to re-engage the member as a happy, valued and participating member of the Craft.

- However diligent and skilled you may be in screening applicants for your Lodge, there will always be some members who decide that Freemasonry is not for them and who resign at an early point.
- Other resignations tend to be for one or more of the following reasons:
    1. Difficulty attending because the Lodge does not suit work or family circumstances
    2. Disappointment or dissatisfaction
    3. Difficulties with another member or members
    4. A change in one or more circumstances, such as age, transport, health, family, employment, financial issues.
- In all these cases, resignations can often be anticipated in advance if the warning signs are recognised.
- If you recognise the warning signs and respond early to these circumstances, you may well avert resignations before they happen.
- If you miss the warning signs or don't take action taken and a member submits their resignation, it will be very difficult to persuade them to reverse their decision.

WARNING SIGNS

- A reduction in the pattern of attendance or participation is the key indicator of a potential resignation.
- Such changes in patterns often follow an event that may have been missed or underestimated by others, but which may have been of great significance to the member concerned.
- In some cases, personality differences or issues prompt members to leave their Lodge, although they might be content to continue in active membership of another Lodge.
- Brethren who are experiencing a change of circumstances or difficult times in their lives sometimes offer their resignation precisely when Freemasonry could be on hand to render assistance and support.
- Those who move home or make other changes to their lifestyle may consider resigning from the Lodge.
- Many who do resign are reluctant to disclose to members of the Lodge the REAL reason why they did so.
- For example, many cite a change in work or family circumstance rather than tell the Lodge that, for example, the start time for Lodge meetings does not match their lifestyle or they are not enjoying Freemasonry as much as they hoped.
- Other warning signs of a potential resignation include:
    - unwillingness to take office, commit to ritual or assist with Lodge activities
    - a lack of preparation prior to Lodge meetings or events
    - delays in paying the lodge subscription
    - not responding to telephone calls, emails or letters.

GUIDANCE FOR LODGES

- Review and use the guidance in the Engage elements to respond to declining attendance.
- Encourage all members to be alert to the warning signs of a potential resignation.
- If warning signs are noticed, ask the Lodge member best placed to address the issue (eg, Lodge Secretary, Almoner or Mentor, or the member's Personal Mentor or sponsor) to contact the member.
- Take early action to:
  - identify the needs, concerns and expectations of any member who may be at risk of resigning
  - address those needs and concerns and provide support as far as is possible within the Lodge
  - refer the matter to the Province if the Lodge is unable to resolve the issue to mutual satisfaction.
- On receipt of a notice of resignation, report the matter to the Lodge Almoner and to the Metropolitan / Provincial / District office without delay.
- Many Metropolitan / Provincial / Districts have their own guidance for this process and the Members' Pathway materials are provided to complement and support local initiatives.
- Do not accept the resignation until:
  - the Lodge Almoner and / or others have made contact with the member
  - the Lodge has had the opportunity to invite a member to withdraw their resignation.
- "Resignation - the opportunity to reconsider" sets out how a Lodge can invite a member to withdraw their resignation.
- If the resignation is due to a decline in circumstances (such as finances or health), arrange for the Lodge Almoner to offer support to the member and their family.
- Inform those who do resign their Lodge membership that, unless they also resign from the Craft, they continue to be a Freemason and may visit Lodges as an "Unattached Freemason", subject to the rules in force at the time (see "Rules governing attendance by Unattached Freemasons").
- Accept that if the Lodge cannot retain a member, it may still be possible for the Province to retrieve them if they move to another Lodge.
- If a member resigns due to their relocation to another area, contact the Provincial office to trigger the migration process (see "Managing Migration" for details) and encourage the member to retain their membership at least until they have joined a Lodge in their new locality.
- If many members resign in a relatively short period, conduct a review of the Lodge and be willing to adapt to make the Lodge more attractive and engaging.
- In such cases, the guidance in "Lessons learned from losses" will also help.

SUGGESTED GUIDANCE FOR PROVINCIAL GRAND LODGES

- Encourage Lodge Secretaries, Lodge Almoners, Lodge Mentors and Personal Mentors to recognise warning signs and take early action to identify, address and refer issues, as detailed in the section above.
- Establish a system for conducting exit interviews of those who resign from their Lodge (see "Understanding the real reasons for losses").
- Implement the migration system (see "Migration flow chart"), as approved and adopted by the Provincial Grand Masters' Forum in November 2015, to retain in the Craft any member who relocates to another area.